

Question #4: Analyze the underlying causes behind the increasing prominence of populism across Europe.

The definition of populism has evolved since the rise of the ideology in the late 1880s with the People's Party in the United States. Fundamentally, it has turned into an opposition between "the people" and "the elite," often anti-establishment and anti-institutional. Populism does not fall along one party line, but manifests on both sides of the political spectrum. The Podemos party in Spain is an example of left-wing populism, emerging from the austerity measures imposed upon Spain and appealing to the people through a left-wing ideology focused on broader political representation and economic solutions to the crisis. This string of populism still calls upon nationalistic tactics by emphasizing national pride and social welfare instead of anti-immigration sentiment. In Germany, the Alternative for Democracy (AfD) party serves as a prime example of right-wing populism, criticizing the state's perceived openness to immigration, economic sanctions against Russia, and government failure to protect the manufacturing sector. Populism surged across Europe in the early 21st century due to local cultural attitudes and economic realities, but took a permanent footing with the 2008 financial crisis. While both cultural and economic factors fueled the rise of populism in Europe, the decisive catalyst was the economic dislocation following the Great Financial Crisis, which created conditions of insecurity that later fueled nativist populism during the 2015 migration crisis.

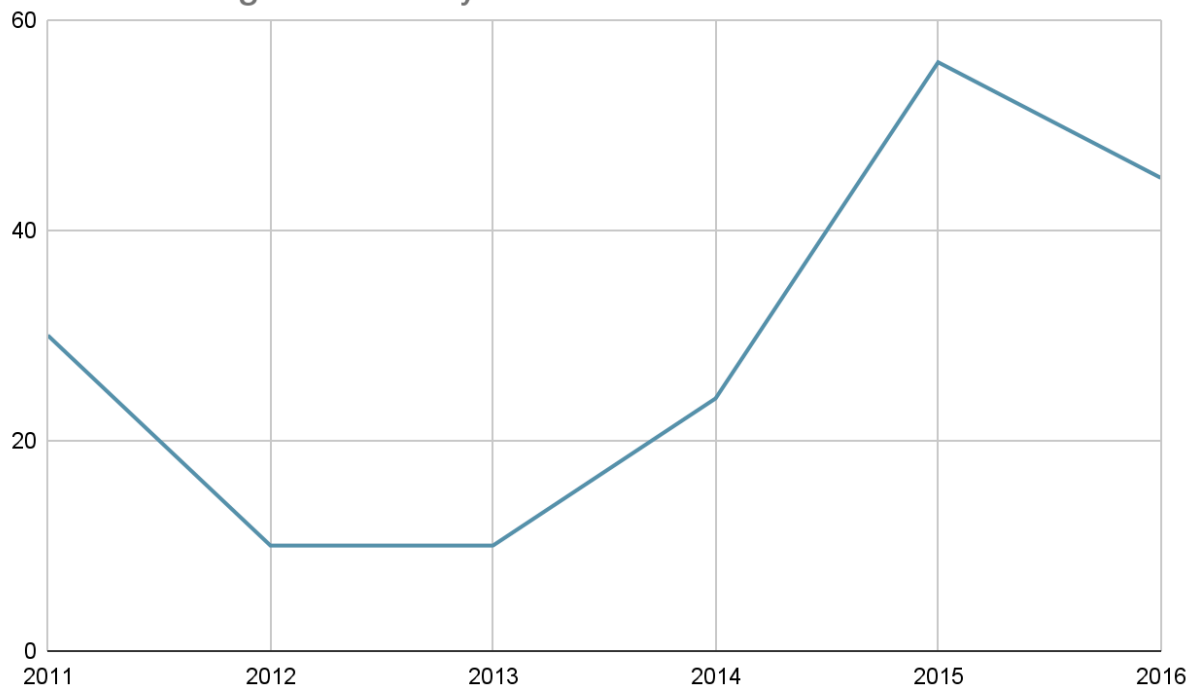
The 2008 financial crisis and broader Eurozone debt crisis caused mass unemployment throughout Europe, with countries in Southern Europe particularly affected. In Spain, the unemployment rate went from 8.2% in 2007, when the EU average was 7.1%, to a high of 24.4% in 2013, when the EU average was 10.3%.¹ Within countries like Greece and Spain, austerity measures imposed by the EU began to deepen inequality and weaken trust in EU institutions like the ECB and European Commission. This created an opening for parties with populist sentiment to come in and appeal to the disillusioned local citizen, promising to restore sovereignty over economic policy and reject austerity imposed by the broader European Union. Looking at the example of Spain, Spanish citizens faced harsh austerity measures which built up resentment while the unemployment rate continued to rise in the short-term. The Indignados Movement (15-M Movement) began in May 2011, consisting of young, unemployed Spaniards protesting against the harsh austerity measures and the high unemployment rate. From this, the Podemos party launched, gaining momentum in the 2014 elections, gaining 7.98% in the 2014 elections for the European Parliament and coming in 3rd in Spain's 2015 general elections. Greece's Syriza party, a left-wing populist party fighting against austerity measures in Greece, gained 36.3% of the vote in 2015 in the Hellenic Parliament elections.

¹ <https://www.macrotrends.net/global-metrics/countries/esp/spain/unemployment-rate>

The 2015 surge in nativist populism after the economic factors soared following the Eurozone crisis introduced a string of populism characterized by cultural superiority and nationalism. In Europe, this string of populism became popular in countries less directly affected by the economic crisis but with a higher perception of a loss of control and imposition to give to other countries across the Eurozone. AfD shifted from euro-skepticism to anti-immigration, using far-right nationalist rhetoric to emphasize the superiority of German citizens and blame migration for Germany's problems, instead of the economic elite. Both forms of populism use the tactics of blaming the elite; nativist populism uses identity-based politics to do so while economic populism focuses on gaining economic sovereignty over the elites. The graph below shows the times when respondents were most bothered by immigration, declining from 2011 to 2012 to then increase drastically during the migration crisis in 2015.

Immigration Top Two-Issue: Source - ICMPD²

% of respondents reporting that immigration is one of the top two issues affecting their country and the EU



Populism surged across Europe in 2015, with populism becoming significantly more popular in countries like Austria, Estonia, Italy, the Czech Republic, and Greece, marked by high feeling of resentment towards local government for the problems of the immigration crisis and continued backlash and economic insecurity following the 2008 financial crisis.

The economic insecurity amplifies cultural fears and creates a window for outsiders to become scapegoats. When jobs and welfare are being threatened, citizens look for causes of their problems. It then becomes easy for right-wing populist parties to blame these issues on immigrants and minority groups to create cultural backlash. This comes from the economic roots of the conflict, with European cultural backlash rooted in the aftermath of the 2008 financial crisis. The economic catastrophe left Europeans feeling disillusioned with the EU and looking to blame outsiders for impacting their lives, opening up the anti-immigration rhetoric spread through these right-wing populist parties.

Looking at the example of Greece, there is a direct correlation between the number of votes for the Syriza party and the increasing unemployment rate. Looking at the last 10 elections in Greece, the main surges for Syriza come with the 2012 economic crisis and the 2015 migration crisis. This supports the argument that the hardened economy opened up space for the Syriza part to create a populist platform, with their highest numbers coming during times where Greek citizens were most susceptible to populist rhetoric.

Greek Unemployment Rate during Election Years: Source - Macrotrends

Election	Greek Unemployment Rate ³	Syriza Seats in the Hellenic Parliament (out of 300)
2004	10.63	6
2007	8.35	14
2009	9.55	13
May 2012	23.1	52
June 2012	24.4	71
January 2015	25.7	149
September 2015	25.0	145
2019	17.05	86
May 2023	10.8	71
June 2023	11.1	47

³ <https://www.macrotrends.net/global-metrics/countries/grc/greece/unemployment-rate>

Populism's spread across Europe foundationally comes from economic hardship after the 2008 financial crisis. The migration crisis did not cause the surge in populism but created an opportunity to move pure economic protest and anti-elite rhetoric to cultural protectionism and nativist resentment. Together, these crises transformed temporary economic frustration into a lasting political realignment, embedding populist parties into mainstream politics across Europe.

Question #10: Numerous nationalist parties across Europe are advocating for greater autonomy for member states while seeking to diminish the authority of European institutions. What are your thoughts on this phenomenon?

In the context of the modern European Union, nationalism is a political ideology that prioritizes national sovereignty, cultural identity, and resistance to supranational authority. Nationalistic movements like Brexit have reshaped the structure of the European Union, fully pulling Britain out of the EU primarily due to spreading nationalist sentiment and desire to take back control. Other movements like Hungary's illiberal democracy, promoted by Orban, prioritize national sovereignty and are at the forefront of domestic politics, with Orban holding the Prime Minister role since 2010. Nationalism is grounded in real concerns about self-determination and democratic voice, but modern challenges like financial crises, migration flows, climate change, and geopolitical threats transcend national borders. EU authority must be strengthened, not weakened, even though aspects of EU economic governance have unintentionally fueled nationalist backlash.

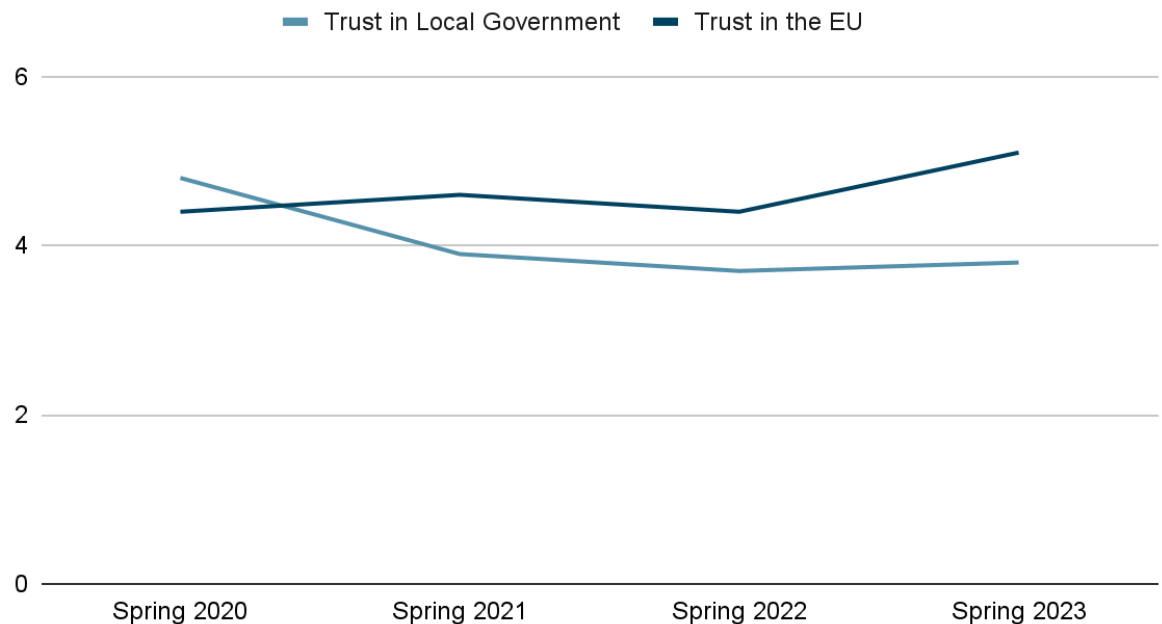
National identity creates a sense of cultural cohesion and democratic participation that benefits the social and economic environment within individual countries. The motivation through a sense of national pride and ability to see tangible differences within your local economy and government benefits citizens to work harder and derive more from their country. Local governments also seem more approachable and accountable than Brussels, housing the elites to rule from afar instead of on the ground within the country. Crises that deeply impact everyday citizens and connect them to their country, like the migration influx, made citizens feel disconnected from the EU decisions made from afar. There is a real need for this sense of national pride and accountability, but it is insufficient to take over Europe.

Strong EU institutions are essential for economic stability, cohesive foreign policy, migration and border protection, and democratic protection. Particularly within crises, the EU is essential to maintain trust and stability between countries. The ECB prevents financial collapse, as seen with COVID recovery and the Greek & Spanish sovereign debt crises. The singular European market also gives small states bargaining power globally, bringing economic benefit to those individual states and the broader European Union. Cross-border regulation helps to prevent tax evasion, financial contagion, and supply-chain disruptions, all heightened during periods of economic crises. During the COVID-19 pandemic, trust in the EU was higher than trust in local

governments due to their ability to manage the crisis and rule with a heavier hand than local governments.

Trust in EU vs Local Government: Source - Social Europe

Trust in the EU vs Local Government



Measured on a scale from 1-10, this chart uses e-series data from Eurofound to measure trust citizens across the EU have in their local government compared with the broader EU. After COVID-19, trust in local governments dropped while trust in the EU remained stable and began to increase, due to the difficulty for smaller governments to manage the crisis and the strength in broader crisis management by the larger institution.

On the political side, foreign policy depends on EU coordination. Russia's invasion of Ukraine shows a clear example that national militaries alone are insufficient and the broader policies of sanctions, energy diversification, and refugee policy depend on EU coordination. NATO helps strengthen these policies, but only the EU can coordinate economic, legal, and border policies. Migration and border protection is also greatly strengthened by the tools of the broader EU, as no national border can be secured without shared EU asylum and relocation mechanisms. Individual national responses in 2015 failed, showing the collective response is much more effective. Additionally, EU rule-of-law mechanisms protect citizens when national governments backslide. A prime example of this protection is Hungary's erosion of checks and balances with Orban's takeover of the major media outlets and limited academic freedom, triggering Article 7 in the European Parliament, freezing EU funds for violating rule-of-law standards. The ECJ helps ensure independent courts and electoral fairness, creating a system of EU institutions that can maintain or gain trust in crises.

However, the EU's mishaps with economic governance ends up fueling nationalistic system, showing the fault with the asymmetric structure of the Eurozone that creates a political paradox. Since the EU has a monetary union without a full fiscal union, it creates a sense of incomplete integration. The forced austerity upon Greece, Spain, and Italy during the Eurozone crisis and the burden placed upon stronger states like Germany created resentment toward Brussels for the economic pain, even though deeper integration could have helped mitigate the crisis from the beginning. Nationalist parties exploit the gap, with Italian parties using rhetoric against the EU for destroying their growth and German ideology focusing on the burden in bailing out irresponsible states. The flaws in integration fuel nationalism, and this sense of nationalism created blocks a fully integrated EU, creating an inescapable cycle.

Nationalism across Europe reflects genuine desires for cultural identity, democratic accountability, and local control, yet these impulses cannot substitute the collective strength the European Union provides. No individual state can secure long-term stability without the shared protection and benefits of the European Union. The paradox, however, is that the EU's incomplete economic architecture contributes to nationalist disillusionment, producing backlash that obstructs deeper integration. Strengthening EU institutions, including those to fight against rule of law violations like seen in Hungary and Poland, is essential to channel nationalism into a model of sovereignty that is shared rather than weaponized.